communism, where he discovered the leader on the floor. By 3:00 a.m. on 2 March, Politburo members had arrived at the dacha and debated what to do. For several hours more, nobody dared call a doctor. What if Stalin were to regain consciousness, and open his eyes only to see a doctor – *a doctor!* – hovering over his bed? He would surely think this was a plot to murder him and would have those responsible shot. Stalin's personal physician wasn't present, because he was at the time in a basement cell of the Lubyanka prison – undergoing torture for suggesting that Stalin needed more rest. By the time the Politburo members decided to bring in medical experts, the danger had passed. Stalin never woke up.[123]

You may conclude from this litany of disasters that the Stalinist system was totally dysfunctional. Its ruthless disregard for truth caused it not only to inflict terrible suffering on hundreds of millions of people but also to make colossal diplomatic, military and economic errors and to devour its own leaders. However, such a conclusion would be misleading.

In a discussion of the abysmal failure of Stalinism in the early phase of the Second World War, two points complicate the narrative. First, democratic countries like France, Norway and the Netherlands made at the time diplomatic errors as great as those of the USSR, and their armies performed even worse. Second, the military machine that crushed the Red Army, the French army, the Dutch army and numerous other armies was itself built by a totalitarian regime. So whatever conclusion we draw from the years 1939–41, it cannot be that totalitarian networks necessarily function worse than democratic ones. The history of Stalinism reveals many potential drawbacks of totalitarian information networks, but that should not blind us to their potential advantages.

When one considers the broader history of the Second World War and its outcome, it becomes evident that Stalinism was in fact one of the most successful political systems ever devised – if we define 'success' purely in terms of order and power while disregarding all considerations of ethics and human well-being. Despite – or perhaps because of – its utter lack of compassion and its callous attitude to truth, Stalinism was singularly efficient at maintaining order on a gigantic scale. The relentless barrage of fake news and conspiracy theories helped to keep hundreds of millions of people in line. The collectivisation of Soviet agriculture led to mass enslavement and starvation but also laid the foundations for the country's rapid industrialisation. Soviet disregard for quality control might have